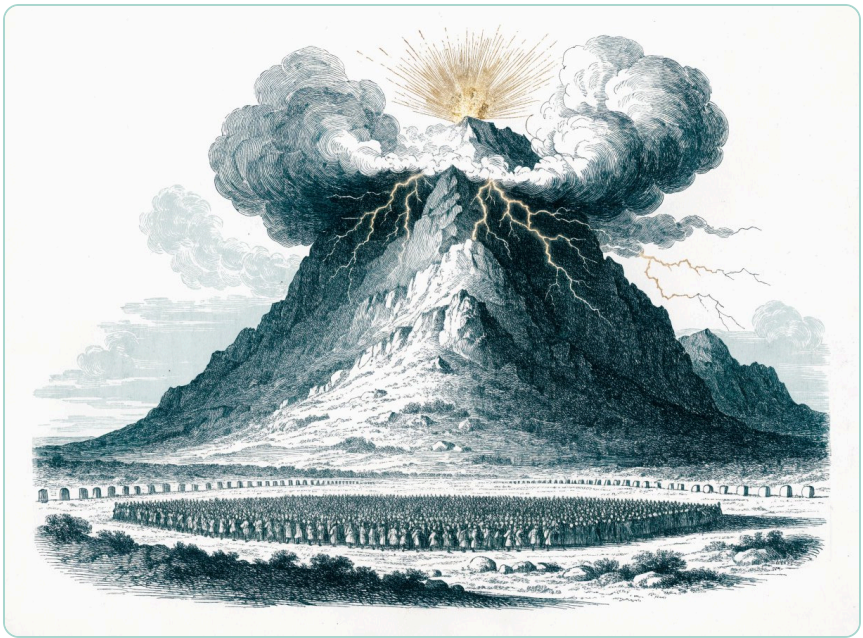
490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 9 OF 26

Sinai: The Law and the Covenant

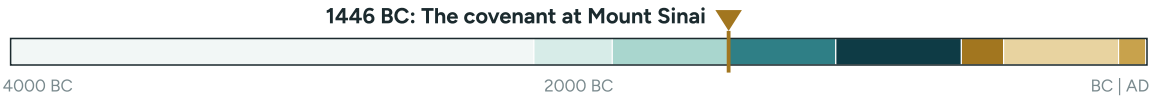
Exodus 19–24; 32



David S. Jones

October 17, 2026

YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 9



Introduction: Rescue Comes First

Picture a couple adopting a little boy out of a bad situation. They sign the papers, carry him out to the car, and bring him home. Only then, after he is already their son, do they sit down with him at the kitchen table and explain how their family lives: we tell the truth here, we are kind to each other, we eat dinner together, you are safe. The house rules do not make him their son. The rules show him what it looks like to live as one.

That is the order of the book of Exodus, and it is one of the most important things to understand about the whole Bible. God did not come to Israel in Egypt and say, "Keep these commandments, and then I will rescue you." He rescued them first, by the blood of the lamb and the parting of the sea. Then, about seven weeks later, at the third new moon (Ex. 19:1), he brought them to a mountain in the desert called Sinai, and there he gave them his law.

God had called Israel "my firstborn son" (Ex. 4:22), so the adoption picture fits. One caution: God rescued the whole nation, yet not everyone who walked out of Egypt trusted him (Heb. 3:16–19). Being in the camp never saved anyone. Faith in God's promise did.

Last week we watched the rescue. This week we watch God bind himself to the people he rescued in a covenant, and give them the Ten Commandments. You will see God's holiness, the purpose of the law, the first great breach of the covenant, and why God promised a better covenant (Heb. 8:6).

The Word: Torah

> **Psalm 1:1–2** *"Blessed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the wicked, nor stands in the way of sinners, nor sits in the seat of scoffers; but his delight is in the law of the LORD, and on his law he meditates day and night."*

תּוֹרָה *(torah, "law, instruction")*

the usual Hebrew word for God's law: teaching that includes commands

יָרָה (yarah)

"to point, to teach"

The verb can mean to aim or point the way. In one form it means to teach or direct someone.

→

תּוֹרָה (torah)

"instruction"

A parent's instruction can be called *torah*: "forsake not your mother's teaching" (Prov. 1:8). God's law is a Father pointing out the way.

Payoff: When we hear "law," we think of police and courtrooms. *Torah* certainly includes rules and penalties, but the word itself carries the warmth of a parent teaching a child. That is why the psalmist could say, "Oh how I love your law! It is my meditation all the day" (Ps. 119:97). The same word came to name the first five books of the Bible, the books of Moses. The law at Sinai was not a ladder for slaves to climb out of Egypt. It was a Father teaching his freed children how to walk.

Part One: On Eagles' Wings

Sinai is the mountain also called Horeb, where God spoke to Moses from the burning bush (Lesson 2). Back then God gave him a sign: "when you have brought the people out of Egypt, you shall serve God on this mountain" (Ex. 3:12). Now Moses was back, and the whole nation was with him.

When Israel camped at the foot of Sinai, God called Moses up the mountain and gave him a message for the people. Listen to what comes first:

> **Exodus 19:4–6** *"You yourselves have seen what I did to the Egyptians, and how I bore you on eagles' wings and brought you to myself. Now therefore, if you will indeed obey my voice and keep my covenant, you shall be my treasured possession among all peoples, for all the earth is mine; and you shall be to me a kingdom of priests and a holy nation."*

"I bore you on eagles' wings and brought you to myself." Before a single command, God reminds them of what he did. He brought them out of Egypt to bring them "to myself."

Notice the word "if." God had already rescued them, in the verse before, so this cannot be a deal to earn rescue. The "if" describes how a rescued people would live as his treasured possession and enjoy what he promised, above all life in the land. When Israel later turned away for good, they lost the land and went into exile. But the "if" never reversed the order. Grace came first. Obedience was the shape of life inside the covenant, and God was about to give sacrifices for the times they failed.

And then God tells them what they will be: his "treasured possession," a "kingdom of priests," a "holy nation." A priest stands between God and people. Israel as a whole was meant to show the nations what the true God is like, to be the channel of the blessing God promised Abraham for "all the families of the

earth." Why did God choose them? Moses later says it plainly: "It was not because you were more in number than any other people that the LORD set his love on you and chose you, for you were the fewest of all peoples, but it is because the LORD loves you and is keeping the oath that he swore to your fathers" (Deut. 7:7–8).

Peter takes these same titles and gives them to the church: "But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession, that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light" (1 Pet. 2:9). If you belong to Christ, Exodus 19 is about you too.

Part Two: The Mountain of Fire

On the third day, God came down. "There were thunders and lightnings and a thick cloud on the mountain and a very loud trumpet blast, so that all the people in the camp trembled… Now Mount Sinai was wrapped in smoke because the LORD had descended on it in fire. The smoke of it went up like the smoke of a kiln, and the whole mountain trembled greatly" (19:16–18). God had already told Moses to set boundaries around the mountain. Anyone who touched it was to be put to death (19:12–13).

Remember Lesson 2: God is holy, holy, holy. Sinai shows what that means. The God who rescued them with such tenderness is also a consuming fire, and sinful people cannot simply walk into his presence. After God had spoken the Ten Commandments aloud to the whole people (we turn to them next), they begged Moses: "You speak to us, and we will listen; but do not let God speak to us, lest we die." So "the people stood far off, while Moses drew near to the thick darkness where God was" (20:19, 21). Moses became their go-between, a *mediator*, the word we met in Lesson 5. Moses himself later said, "I stood between the LORD and you" (Deut. 5:5).

Part Three: The Ten Words

Look now at what God spoke from the fire (20:1; Deut. 5:22). The Bible calls them "the Ten Words" (Ex. 34:28, in Hebrew), and they begin, not with a command, but with a reminder: "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery" (20:2). That sentence is the foundation of everything that follows. The Shorter Catechism draws the lesson: "because God is the Lord, and our God, and redeemer, therefore we are bound to keep all his commandments" (WSC 44). We obey because we have been rescued, not in order to be rescued.



"The tablets were the work of God, and the writing was the writing of God, engraved on the tablets" (Ex. 32:16).

The commandments fall into two groups, often pictured as two stone tablets. The first four are about loving God: have no other gods, make no images to worship, do not misuse God's name, and keep the Sabbath holy. The last six are about loving your neighbor: honor your parents, and do not murder, commit adultery, steal, lie about others, or covet what belongs to them.

The Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:1–17)

The preface: "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out…" (20:2)

Love God

Matt 22:37–38 · Deut 6:5

1. No other gods before me
2. No carved image to worship
3. Do not misuse the LORD's name
4. Remember the Sabbath day

Love your neighbor

Matt 22:39 · Lev 19:18

5. Honor your father and mother
6. Do not murder
7. Do not commit adultery
8. Do not steal
9. Do not bear false witness
10. Do not covet

"On these two commandments depend all the Law and the Prophets" (Matt 22:40). The law is love, spelled out.

Jesus summed up the whole law in two sentences. When someone asked him which commandment was greatest, he answered, "You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind. This is the great and first commandment. And a second is like it: You shall love your neighbor as yourself. On these two commandments depend all the Law and the Prophets" (Matt. 22:37–40), Jesus' name for the Old Testament Scriptures. The Catechism says the same: "The sum of the ten commandments is to love the Lord our God with all our heart, with all our soul, with all our strength, and with all our mind; and our neighbor as ourselves" (WSC 42).

You may be wondering about the fourth commandment. If the Ten Commandments still bind us, should Christians rest on Saturday? The Sabbath goes back to creation, before Israel existed: God rested on the seventh day and blessed it (Gen. 2:3; Lesson 3). So one day in seven belongs to God for all people. What changed is which day. Jesus rose on the first day of the week, and from then on his people gathered on that day (Acts 20:7) and called it "the Lord's day" (Rev. 1:10). The Westminster Confession says that from Christ's resurrection the Sabbath "was changed into the first day of the week, which, in Scripture, is called the Lord's day," to be kept "as the Christian Sabbath" (WCF 21.7). Keeping it means setting aside ordinary work and recreation to give the day to worship, and to works of necessity and mercy (WCF 21.8). It is a weekly gift, and a small taste of the rest that remains for God's people (Heb. 4:9).

Part Four: What Is the Law For?

If you are new to the Bible, you have probably wondered: do Christians still have to keep all of Moses' laws? Do we avoid pork and wear clothes of one fabric? The Westminster Confession gives a clear and helpful answer by sorting the laws God gave at Sinai into three kinds.

The **moral law**, summed up in the Ten Commandments, shows God's own holy character, and it "doth forever bind all," believers and unbelievers alike (WCF 19.5). The **ceremonial laws** (sacrifices, priests, food laws, festivals) were pictures "prefiguring Christ, his graces, actions, sufferings, and benefits," and they "are now abrogated," set aside, because Christ has come (WCF 19.3). The **judicial laws** were the civil laws of the nation of Israel, and they "expired together with the State of that people," though their "general equity," their underlying justice, still teaches us (WCF 19.4).



And what does the moral law do in our lives? Since the Reformation, Christians have usually named three uses. First, it is a **mirror**. It shows us our sin and drives us to Christ. "Through the law comes knowledge of sin" (Rom. 3:20), and so "the law was our guardian until Christ came, in order that we might be justified by faith" (Gal. 3:24). Second, it is a **restraint**. Even in people who do not know God, the law's warnings hold back evil and keep a society livable (1 Tim. 1:9–10). Third, for those who belong to Christ, it is a **guide**, "a rule of life informing them of the will of God, and their duty" (WCF 19.6). Believers are "not under the law, as a covenant of works, to be thereby justified, or condemned" (WCF 19.6). That is the covenant Adam broke in Lesson 3, and Christ kept it in our place. So the law can no longer condemn a believer. It still shows us how to love.

The mirror shows a hard truth: no one keeps the law. "No mere man since the fall is able in this life perfectly to keep the commandments of God, but doth daily break them in thought, word and deed" (WSC 82). James says, "whoever keeps the whole law but fails in one point has become guilty of all of it" (James 2:10). The law is holy, "and the commandment is holy and righteous and good" (Rom. 7:12). The fault lies with us.

Part Five: The Blood of the Covenant, and a Golden Calf

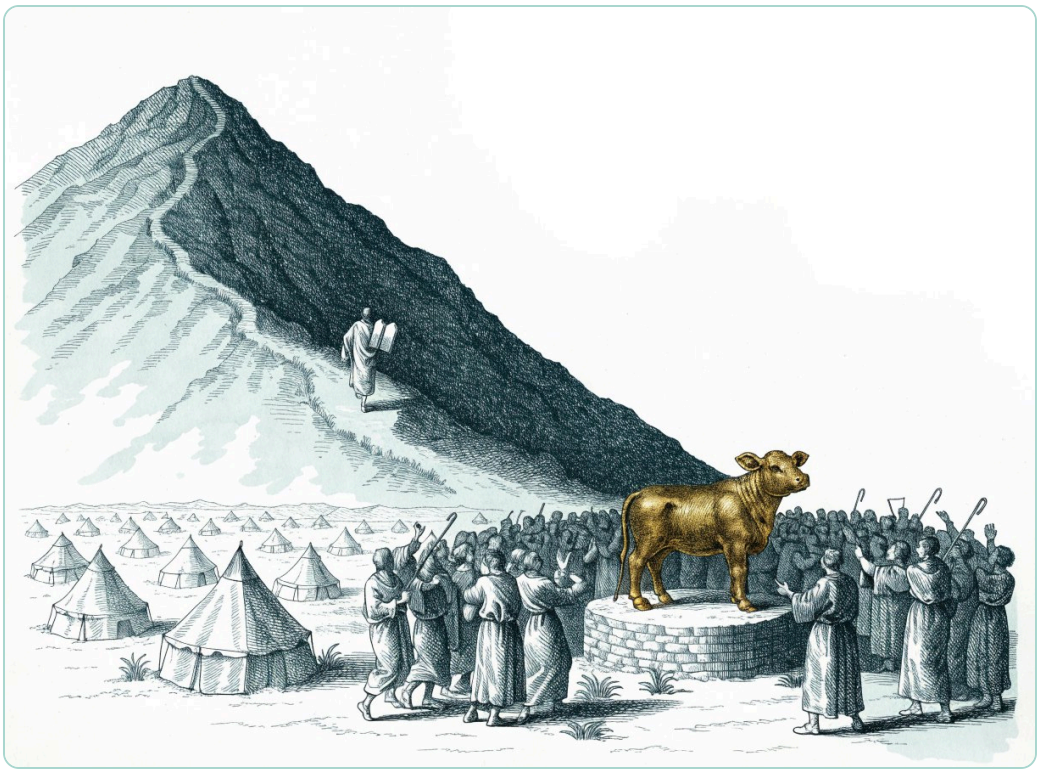


"He… built an altar at the foot of the mountain, and twelve pillars, according to the twelve tribes of Israel" (Ex. 24:4).

After the Ten Commandments, God gave Moses more detailed laws, recorded in Exodus 21–23. Moses wrote them down, and Exodus calls the scroll "the Book of the Covenant" (24:7). These chapters show the Ten Commandments at work in a farming people's daily life: what happens when an ox gores a neighbor, what to do when a borrowed animal dies, why a judge must never take a bribe. Some of these laws sound harsh or strange to us, because they were written for Israel as a nation in a hard ancient world. They are the judicial laws we met in Part Four. But listen to their heart: "You shall not wrong a sojourner or oppress him, for you were sojourners in the land of Egypt" (22:21).

In Exodus 24 the covenant was sealed. Moses wrote down God's words and built an altar at the foot of the mountain with twelve pillars for the twelve tribes. Young men offered sacrifices, and Moses threw half the blood against the altar. Then he read the Book of the Covenant to the people, and they answered, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do, and we will be obedient" (24:7). He threw the rest of the blood on the people, saying, "Behold the blood of the covenant that the LORD has made with you in accordance with all these words" (24:8). Then the leaders of Israel went up the mountain, and "they beheld God, and ate and drank" (24:11). A meal in God's presence, sealed by blood.

And then Moses went up the mountain for forty days to receive the stone tablets. Down in the camp, the people grew impatient. "Up, make us gods who shall go before us," they told Aaron. He collected their gold earrings and made a golden calf, and they said, "These are your gods, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt!" (32:1, 4). They feasted and danced around it.



"And as soon as he came near the camp and saw the calf and the dancing, Moses' anger burned hot, and he threw the tablets out of his hands and broke them" (Ex. 32:19).

Weeks after promising, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do," they broke the first two commandments at once. When Moses came down and saw it, he smashed the tablets at the foot of the mountain (32:19).

Then Moses did something astonishing. He went back up to God and begged for the people: "Alas, this people has sinned a great sin." He asked God to forgive them, and if not, "please blot me out of your book that you have written" (32:31–32). Moses would rather be lost with his people than saved without them. God refused: "Whoever has sinned against me, I will blot out of my book" (32:33). Moses was a sinner too, and no sinner can carry another's guilt. Judgment did fall on the camp (32:28, 35). But God did forgive, renewed the covenant, and gave new tablets. And when he did, he proclaimed his name: "The LORD, the LORD, a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness" (34:6).

When Moses came down the mountain with the new tablets, his face was shining from speaking with God, and the people were afraid to come near him. So Moses put a veil over his face (34:29–35). Paul picks up this scene in 2 Corinthians 3. The glory at Sinai was real, he says, but it was fading, and words on stone could not change a heart. "When one turns to the Lord, the veil is removed," and "we all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another" (2 Cor. 3:16, 18). Moses reflected God's glory for a little while. Everyone who turns to Christ beholds it and is slowly changed by it.

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE God came down on the mountain in fire, and the people had to stand far off. But in the very next chapters he tells Moses, "let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst" (Ex. 25:8), a holy place, here the tabernacle tent. The holy God who could not be approached on the mountain is about to move into the middle of the camp. That is Lesson 10.

THE LAMB The covenant was sealed with blood: "Behold the blood of the covenant" (Ex. 24:8). On the night before he died, Jesus lifted the cup and used almost the same words: "This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many" (Mark 14:24). Hebrews explains why: "without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness of sins" (Heb. 9:22).

The Turn: A Better Covenant, a Better Mediator

Israel said, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do," and could not do it. Neither can we. If all we took from Sinai were the law's demands, the law would only be a mirror showing us how far we fall short, and a mountain of fire we could never climb.

But God did not leave it there. Centuries later, after Israel had broken the covenant again and again, God promised through Jeremiah a *new* covenant, "not like the covenant that I made with their fathers… my covenant that they broke." This time, God said, "I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts… For I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more" (Jer. 31:31–34). The trouble at Sinai was never a shortage of grace. Sinai had a mediator, a blood sacrifice, and a God who called himself merciful and gracious. Hebrews says God "finds fault with them" (Heb. 8:8), with hearts that would not keep what they promised. Believers in Israel were saved the same way we are, by grace through faith in the Messiah God had promised (Lesson 1; WCF 7.5). The new covenant brings that same salvation in its full light: the law written on the heart of every member, sin forgiven once for all, and the Mediator himself come in the flesh.

Jesus is the one who brings that new covenant. He said, "Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them" (Matt. 5:17). He kept the law perfectly, every commandment, in thought, word, and deed, for us. Paul says, "by the one man's obedience the many will be made righteous" (Rom. 5:19). When you trust Christ, God counts his perfect record as yours. Moses asked to be blotted out and could not be. Jesus went further. He was "cut off out of the land of the living, stricken for the transgression of my people" (Isa. 53:8), redeeming us "by becoming a curse for us" (Gal. 3:13). "God has done what the law, weakened by the flesh, could not do. By sending his own Son… he condemned sin in the flesh, in order that the righteous requirement of the law might be fulfilled in us" (Rom. 8:3–4).

Hebrews puts the two mountains side by side. You have not come to Sinai, "a blazing fire and darkness and gloom and a tempest," where even Moses said, "I tremble with fear." You have come to Mount Zion, the city of the living God, "and to Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant, and to the sprinkled blood that speaks a better word than the blood of Abel" (Heb. 12:18–24). So stop trying to climb the mountain of

fire on your own. Turn from your sin and trust Jesus, who kept the law you broke and bore the curse you deserved. Then the law becomes for you what it was for Israel at the foot of Sinai: a Father's instruction to a child he has already brought home.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read the story.** Read Exodus 19–20, 24, and 32. Notice the order: rescue, then covenant, then failure, then mercy.

2. **Start with grace.** Before you read the Ten Commandments, read Exodus 20:2 out loud. Remind yourself what God has already done for you.

3. **Use the mirror.** Take one commandment a day this week. Ask honestly where you have broken it in thought, word, or deed, and confess it to God.

4. **Find your golden calf.** What do you turn to when God seems slow, like Israel at the foot of the mountain? Name it and turn it over to him.

5. **Love, spelled out.** Pick one of the last six commandments and turn it into a positive act of love for a neighbor this week.

6. **Memorize Exodus 20:2.** "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery."

Before Lesson 10: *Read Exodus 25–27 and 40. Lesson 10 shows how the holy God moved into the middle of his people's camp.*

For Discussion

1. Why does it matter that God rescued Israel before he gave them the law? What would change if it were the other way around?
2. God called Israel a "kingdom of priests." What does it mean for the church to be "a royal priesthood" today (1 Pet. 2:9)?
3. Why were the people afraid at Sinai? Is that kind of fear of God healthy or harmful? Why?
4. Look at the moral, ceremonial, and judicial laws diagram. Which law have you heard Christians argue about? How does this help?
5. Which use of the law (mirror, restraint, guide) have you experienced most? Explain.
6. Israel made the golden calf while Moses was gone only forty days. Why do you think they turned so fast? Where do you see that tendency in yourself?
7. Moses asked to be blotted out for Israel and could not be. Jesus was cut off for his people and became a curse for them. What does that tell you about him?

Sources & For Further Study

- Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), chapter 19, “Of the Law of God,” especially 19.3–6. Westminster Shorter Catechism (1647), Q. 41–44 and Q. 82.
- On תּוֹרָה and יָרָה: Brown, Driver, and Briggs, *Hebrew and English Lexicon*; Koehler and Baumgartner, *HALOT*, s.v.
- For further reading: Kevin DeYoung, *The Ten Commandments: What They Mean, Why They Matter, and Why We Should Obey Them*; Philip Graham Ryken, *Written in Stone*; John Calvin, *Institutes* 2.7–8 (on the law).



David S. Jones

Author of *Seventy Times Seven: On the God Who Forgives Past All Counting*. He teaches Scripture every week or so at 490.life, serves on the worship teams at Scottsdale Bible Church, and serves in the men’s group, The Forge, helping to disciple men and pointing them to Jesus. He coaches and mentors men one-to-one and speaks to churches and men’s groups.

© 2026 490 Life Publishing · David S. Jones · Scripture quotations from the ESV · 490.life